Curiously, Bose was criticised by both the BJP and the TMC after he visited Rishra in Hooghly district on April 4 to survey the situation after the Ramnavami communal riots. Bose said, "I will see, analyse and decide...there will be solid action." Leader of the opposition Suvendu Adhikari wasn't impressed. "I want the constitutional head of the state to exercise constitutional powers instead of seeking reports from the government," he said. The TMC, too, was miffed. "The governor... trod the BJP-ordained route against the state's law and order situation...he has come to implement the BJP's agenda," said *Jago Bangla*, wagging its editorial finger.

The latest rift between Bose and the government is over a bill passed in June 2022 that sought to replace the governor as chancellor of state-run universities with the CM. With the bill still unsigned,

LIKE HIS PREDECESSOR, BOSE IS TAKING THE INITIATIVE ON VARIOUS ISSUES, GREATLY WORRYING THE TMC

state education minister Bratya Basu demanded that Bose either sign it or return it. This was after Bose visited the Calcutta, Presidency and Barasat universities within a few days in April and ordered them to submit weekly reports of their activities to him and take his prior permission before major financial decisions. Protesting that Bose did not inform them of his visits, an irate Basu said, "The governor is running amok like an intoxicated elephant".

Like Dhankhar, Bose has started acting on his own initiative on various matters. On February 24, he visited Borshul village in West Burdwan with an agriculture expert to meet farmers and offered 15 of them free training in Chennai. After the Ramnavami violence, Bose opened a special cell at Raj Bhavan for round-the-clock monitoring of the situation. In all this, a concerned TMC government sees Dhankhar's shadow. No wonder Mamata has endorsed Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin's move to unite disaffected CMs of non-BJP ruled states over the alleged non-cooperation of governors. ■

RAJASTHAN

A SUICIDE AND A FEW QUESTIONS

By Rohit Parihar



Two back-to-back incidents in poll-bound Rajasthan have left the Ashok Gehlot-led government red-faced. CM Gehlot claims having taken quick action in both cases, but the Opposition has been handed ammunition to target the Congress and question its government's claims of integrity. First came a video left by a tea vendor who died by suicide in Jaipur on April 17, accusing cabinet minister Mahesh Joshi (among others) of harassment. The next day, question paper leaks came back to haunt the Gehlot regime after the arrest of a Rajasthan Public Service Commission (RPSC) member.

The tea vendor, Ram Prasad Meena, had been living on a plot adjoining a 300-year-old temple in the walled city of Jaipur. Though the family was granted its *patta* (title rights) in 2017, the allotment was challenged before the lokayukta and the file allegedly went missing. When Ram Prasad began constructing a *pucca* house in March this year, the civic body first

BIHAR

A RAJPUT WALKS FREE BACKWARDS

By Amitabh Srivastava



Life convicts getting their sentence commuted is not news usually but the Bihar law department's April 24 release order for 27 lifers who have completed 14 years behind bars has set off a furious debate. And this is because of one name on the list—ex-MP and *bahubali* Anand Mohan Singh. In jail for the past 15 years after his conviction in the 1994 murder of then Gopalganj district magistrate G. Krishnaiah, Mohan has always been a polarising figure, revered by his Rajput castemen but despised by many others. Mohan was accused of inciting the mob that attacked and killed the 1985 batch IAS officer.

The don's release was facilitated by the state home department when it amended the Bihar Police Jail Manuals' Rule No. 481 (1) on April 10, removing "murder of a public servant on duty" from the heinous crimes list which do not qualify for remission. Mohan's discharge, coming with just a year to go for the general election, is not without political ramifications. Traditionally seen as BJP supporters, the Rajputs have a 5 per cent-plus vote share in Bihar and punch way above that in terms of